

ELISHA PARIKH, 17

Runs Eli the Baker and Cakeify Mixes, Mumbai

Owner of two businesses already, Parikh says the best part about being an entrepreneur is creating something that is her own. "When people ask me for advice about baking, I feel such a huge sense of satisfaction." Parikh is currently attending a boarding school in the UK but frequently flies back to her home in Mumbai to oversee business. "It's not just baking anymore. I am also thinking of finance, operations for the company. I have also started writing articles and host a podcast on baking. This is a field that has so many opportunities, and I want to improve my skills in all of them," she says. Would she ever consider working for another company? "I have been running Eli the Baker since I was 13. I enjoy getting to do my own thing, and I might not get that working for another firm," she says.

change than to live a life of regret and compulsion," says 23-year-old Anupam Garg from Indore, who after two years as a graphic designer decided to pursue a course in sociology instead.

With their confidence and energy, there's a lot Gen Z brings to the table. Data from LinkedIn India shows that Gen Z workers love 'desk bombing', that is, approaching colleagues for informal conversations, impromptu ideations and easy collaborations. "Many of them bring the fearless attitude due to liberal grooming at home. This makes it easy to deploy them in customer-facing roles. Their ability to turn around work in quick time when they are in the flow makes them ideal for shorter deadline projects. From a cultural point of view, they are less inhibited and bring higher energy to workplaces. Their infectious enthusiasm drives the vibrancy of teams and brands alike," says Kamal Karanth, co-founder of Xpheno.

And Gen Z does all this while being unapologetic about voicing their concerns. "They are among the most expressive



"THIS GENERATION WANTS TO BE SURE BEFORE DEVOTING THEMSELVES TO SOMETHING. MANY OF THEM WOULD LIKE TO EXPLORE DIFFERENT OPPORTUNITIES BEFORE DECIDING ON A CAREER PATH"

DINESH SINGH
Educationist

of generations. 'Better opportunities' is the reason stated most often during exit interviews. While they appreciate the growth trajectories offered by an employer, they also do not flinch to seek better opportunities," says Karanth.

About half of Gen Z workers also do not believe in traditional hierarchical models that render the top management inaccessible. A survey published in July 2023 by the RPG group, of 4,000 Gen Z workers across 13 cities in India, showed that six in 10 of them would be willing to forgo a better salary for a workplace that values mental health and inclusivity.

Employers are both amused and confounded by this new social contract. "The novel change for me is that my young employees call me by my first name. It is amusing when a 60-year-old will call me 'madam' but a 20-year-old will not in the boardroom. But I've learned not to take offence. It's a difference in perspectives, not respect," says the HR director of an IT firm. There are many like her who've had to relearn how to communicate with